Talking With Dad and Your Siblings About Where His Records Are and Who Would Handle an Application

Who should be there, how to open, what to ask and how to write down what's said.

Dad keeps his own files and always has. You'd like to know where things are, and you don't want it to sound like you're taking over.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: to find out, with his permission, where his records are kept and who he'd want handling the paperwork if an application were ever needed. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Dad, first, and whoever he wants. They're his records, so the guest list is his. It may be just the two of you at his kitchen table, with your brothers and sisters told afterward, or everyone together on a Sunday.

If several of you are in the room, pick one person to take notes, and let Dad see what's being written.

How to open

Start with why you're asking, and make it easy for him to say “not today.” The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says that even if it feels awkward, it is important to have an honest conversation about finances. [1]

- “Dad, nothing's wrong and nobody's asking you to change anything. I realized that if you ever wanted a hand with paperwork, I wouldn't know which drawer to open.”
- “I don't need to know amounts. I'd just like to know what records there are and where you keep them.”
- Say what the conversation is for: knowing where things are, and who he'd want helping. Say what it isn't for: taking over his files, or deciding anything about his money or about applying for anything.

What to ask his permission for

Ask for each of these separately. He may say yes to some and not to others, and that's an answer to write down, not something to talk him out of.

- To write down a list of his records and where each one is kept.
- To know where the file is, without going through it.
- To jot down with him the larger money events of recent years, while the details are easy to remember.
- To tell one other person in the family where the list is.
- To bring the list, later on, to a professional.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. Where do you keep things: the statements, the insurance papers, the deed? Which come in the mail, and which are online?

2. Is there anything with paperwork of its own that I wouldn't think to ask about: a retirement account, an investment, a policy from an old job, another piece of property?

3. Have there been any larger money events in recent years that would be easier to write down now than to remember later: something sold, a gift, a large deposit?

4. If a Medicaid application were ever needed, who would you want handling the paperwork, and who should know where the file is?

5. Is there someone you already call about money or legal matters, whose name we should have?

Ask each other, if Dad wants the family involved

1. What does each of us already know about where Dad's records are, and how do we know it?

2. Who has the time, and lives close enough, to help Dad keep the file current if he'd like that?

3. Where does what one of us remembers differ from what Dad said?

How to write down what was said

Use Dad's own words where you can. Where he isn't sure, or two people remember something differently, write both and don't settle it. “Not sure” is worth writing down: it tells you what to look for next.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHERE THE PAPERWORK IS	STILL TO CHECK
“Bank statements are in the rolltop desk, left side. The credit union is all online now.”	Dad	Desk in the den; the credit union's website	
Remembers Dad selling the lot by the lake some years back.	Marcus	Dad thinks the closing papers are in the hall closet	Dad isn't sure of the year. Look for the papers together.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHERE THE PAPERWORK IS	STILL TO CHECK

What not to decide yet

These belong to a later conversation with a professional who knows Dad's state, and your notes are what make that conversation useful. Leave them open.

- Whether or when anyone would apply for anything.
- Whether anything should be moved, retitled, given away or put in someone else's name.
- What a past sale, gift or transfer means for Medicaid.
- Who remembered it right.

What you can decide today

- Where the list will be kept for now, and who Dad wants told.
- Whose name to pencil in, for now, as the person Dad would want handling the paperwork.
- Who will take each open question to his bank, his insurance company or a professional.
- When you'll look at the list together again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything about Dad's accounts or property, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets where his records are, and who he'd want helping, onto one page in his words. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked with Dad, and where his records are and who he'd want helping are on paper in his words. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness